times. When this happened and whether these were later reconstructions—continuous and methodical records of the region's tribes are only available from the thirteenth century[9]—is, of course, conjecture and beside the point for our purposes. As one scholar noted, one way to understand the vexed 'identity of the people of this civilisation' is to see it from the lens of the 'Sanskritisation' theory[10] propounded by the sociologist M.N. Srinivas in the 1950s, which suggested that castes or tribes lower down in the hierarchy sought to gain upward mobility by emulating rituals and practices of dominant or upper castes. Seen from that angle, 'the claim of the Mishmis that they descended from Bhishmaka, the legendary king of Kundil … can be resolved'.[11] The political use of the Krishna-Rukmini legend encapsulated the idea of 'Ek Bharat', or One India, that is at the centre of the BJP's core messaging in the state. There is a direct link between such political imagery and the RSS's groundwork in the Northeast over the past few decades to inculcate a wider Hindu identity in the region.

The BJP's national election victory in 2014 presaged the most dramatic realignment of political power equations in the north-eastern states since Independence. Until 2016, the party had never been elected to power in any of these eight states. It had briefly formed a government once in Arunachal Pradesh (2003) when Gegong Apang, the Congress's longest-serving chief minister in the state, defected and merged his new regional outfit with the party and ran a BJP-led government for a year, before he returned to the Congress.[12] However, in that one-year rule, coinciding with Vajpayee's premiership, the party had not been elected to power. Moreover, until 2016, the BJP had never even finished as the second-best party in an electoral contest in any of the north-eastern states, whether in the national or state assembly polls. Yet, it held office in six of the eight states in the region by 2021. In four of these—Assam (on 24 May 2016 and again on 10 May 2021), Tripura (on 9 March 2018), Arunachal Pradesh (on 31 December 2016, then 29 May 2019) and Manipur (on 15 March 2017)—BJP chief ministers assumed power at the head of multi-party coalitions.[13] The party's first-ever victories in Assam (where it trounced the Congress twice in